

פרשת בהר - בחקתי

זצוקללה"ה, Pearls from the Rov of Tehillos Yisroel,

Translated from the גליון המקוצר of Tehillos Yisroel

"מה ענין שמיטה אצל הר סיני"

רש"י asks regarding the first פסוק of this week's פרשה - Why does the תורה specifically mention that the מצוה of שמיטה was given at הר סיני, weren't all of the מצוות given at הר סיני? רש"י answers that the תורה gives the מצוה of שמיטה as an example. Just as שמיטה was given over with all of its general rules and details at הר סיני so too, all of the מצוות were given over with all of their details at הר סיני. However, we still need to give a reason why the תורה chose this מצוה to be the example for the rest of the מצוות. There is certainly something that can be learned from this.

The אגרא דכלה (written by the author of the בני יששכר) says that the reason הר סיני is mentioned by the מצוה of שמיטה is because just as the תורה was given at הר סיני, which is in the desert, a place which is הפקר (ownerless) and void of all physicality, so too a person who wants to achieve תורה must be willing to leave behind all that he owns. It seems that his intention is that just as it was by הר סיני, when כלל ישראל received the תורה, it was in the desert, which is הפקר (ownerless), so too the year of שמיטה, when a person disowns all of his property (and declares it הפקר), he is then capable of achieving תורה. We also see in the ספרים הקדושים, as well as in the ראשונים, that it is the will of ד' that during the year of שמיטה a person should be free of his physical involvement and sanctify all of his time for the study of תורה. During the year of שמיטה it is as though we are all standing at הר סיני and receiving the תורה anew.



With what has been said, that in order to receive the תורה, one must leave everything behind, we can add that this is true also with regards to achieving the מצוות, all רוחניות, and עבודת ד'. When a person approaches עבודת ד', physicality should not occupy any of his thoughts (at least for the time being) since he is dealing with something so important. Let us imagine a person who finds a great treasure of diamonds but in order to take the treasure he must lower himself into a muddy pit and get his clothes dirty and torn, or even completely destroyed. In order not to lose his clothes, he reaches for the treasure very slowly and carefully. However, by doing so, there are many diamonds that he cannot reach. If this person would be satisfied with this and say "Since I can also get diamonds and also keeps my coat clean, why dirty my coat?", he would certainly be considered a fool because every diamond is worth 50,000 coins and his coat is worth nothing compared to this. Even more so, if we are talking about a loss of many diamonds. What he could

have gained from these diamonds, would purchase 10,000 coats. Due to his foolishness, he is worried about a small loss.



As has been mentioned above, it is impossible to achieve תורה, as well as other achievements ברוחניות, unless one is willing to give up all of גשמיות and pleasures of this world. It is also necessary to give over this חינוך to our children. Without paying attention to the importance of this matter and continuously working on it, it is impossible for one to withstand the נסיונות of this generation. This matter is one of the greatest causes of failure and weakness and what is holding us back from achieving תורה and all of רוחניות, as well as coming close to ד'. We are unwilling to give up the comforts of this world and the lifestyle we have gotten used to. We place too much importance on the opinions of our neighbors and are worried about being looked down upon. If we do not pay attention to the challenges of today, our entire חינוך could fail. Their נסיונות may become too difficult to overcome.

It is very common today that children are surrounded by all kinds of friends, even ones that can harm their spiritual growth. It is very difficult for children (sometimes, even for adults) to give up on these friendships, and the hearts of children are easily won over by their friends. However, if children are accustomed to the מדה of sacrificing גשמיות to attain רוחניות, it will be easy for them to overcome and let go of the friends that can be harmful to their רוחניות. One who is aware of this and is careful in these matters will inherit goodness in this world and in the World to Come, בס"ד.

Additionally, it is important to teach our children to live with אמונה and בטחון in ד'. Without בטחון and אמונה, they will not be able to grow in תורה as well as other רוחניות achievements. This is especially necessary in our times because most of the world is very distant from אמונה and בטחון, and many are walking around with the belief of "בכחי ועוצם ידי", "By the might and power of my own hand". They believe that if they are smart and quick, they will achieve their goals.

It used to be that the תורה world and the בתי מדרשות were filled with אמונה in ד'. Even women and the עמי הארץ, despite the fact that they were not learned, were filled with אמונה and בטחון. It was absorbed into the hearts of their children and this was the reason for their success¹. In today's world, however, if we do not give this over to our children and speak to them continuously about אמונה and בטחון, they will not have another source of where to receive it. Therefore, it is necessary to invest a lot of time in this and daven that our children should grow up with אמונה and בטחון in ד'. It says in תנא דבי אליהו that in order to merit having children that are צדיקים, one should daven and plead to ד' for the success of our children, all the more so in our

¹ Addition from the editor: A question was posed to the אגרות משה: What is the way to succeed in the חינוך of our children? He answered: "Fill them with אמונה and בטחון in ד'". He also said that even though חז"ל have established a specific age for children to be trained in the מצוות, when it comes to אמונה, it begins before the child even knows how to speak.

low generation, where the strength of the **יצר הרע** is breaking all boundaries, much more than in previous generations. Certainly, along with our **תפילות**, we must speak to our children about all of the corruption and challenges of this generation. Praiseworthy is one whose **תורה** is the source of his **אמונה** and he does not have faith in the strength of **טבע**, and is not interested in the wisdoms of the **גויים**. Rather, his desire is only in the **תורה**. With this, he will succeed, **בס"ד**.

Along with what has been said above by the אגרא דכלא, we can give a similar explanation. However, we must first explain what is the ענין of שמיטה מצוה. The מצוה of שמיטה is meant to accustom us with the מדה of בטחון, to completely trust in 'ד, as it says in the (תהילים נ"ה כ"ג) "השליך על ד' יהבך והוא יכלכלך", "Cast your package upon 'ד and He will support you". In truth, the way that 'ד created the world is that אדם הראשון was in גן עדן before the sin and he did not need to do any מלאכה because everything was prepared for him by 'ד and he only had to trust in 'ד. His occupation was to study תורה and fulfill the מצוות. However, after the חטא of עץ הדעת, everything changed and he was cursed with "בזיעת אפך תאכל לחם", "By the sweat of your brow you shall eat". However, the decree was only to the external eye. בפנימיות, the שפע that was designated for us was still coming directly from 'ד, as it says (מלאכי ג' ו') "אני ד' לא שינתי" (מלאכי ג' ו'). The חטא ruined the vessel which holds our שפע and we are unworthy or capable of receiving the שפע unless it is wrapped up and en clothed in טבע.

This is our continuous challenge, we must reveal and acknowledge the **פנימיות** of the matter and realize that our **שפע** is still coming from **ד'**. We must have complete and clear **אמונה** that our **פרנסה** has nothing to do with how clever or smart we are or how much effort we put in, since everything is coming from **ד'**. We must fight our **יצר הרע** not believe or to be drawn after what our physical eyes are tricking us to think because as soon as we fall into **טבע**, we veer away from **אמונה** in **ד'**. However, since this matter is one of the heart, we must actualize this **אמונה** in order not to lose the level we are holding on. Since it is the nature of the physical world to draw one into the way things seem externally, therefore the **תורה** gave us the **מצוה** of **שמיטה**, which forbids us to work the land. Additionally, the **תורה** forbids us to behave as though we are the owners of the land, and we must make the land **הפקר**. The land is open to anyone and everyone, rich and poor alike. By doing so, a person can strongly feel that he is not the **בעל הבית**, and **"לד' הארץ"** **ומלואה**, "Everything belongs to **ד'**". He is the one giving us our **פרנסה** and we must trust only in him.

With what has been said, we can understand that **בטחון** is not just another level that a person achieves. Rather, it is revealing the concealment which is blocking our eyes from seeing the truth and is revealing the pure **אמונה** in **'ד**, that He alone did, does, and will do everything. There is nothing else that can give us our sustenance. When a person acknowledges this truth, not just in his mind, but he actually lives with it, he becomes close to **'ד** and worthy of receiving the **תורה**.

For this reason, before מתן תורה, when ד' wanted to prepare בני"י for קבלת התורה, he fed us מן and placed us in ענני הכבוד. We saw the truth with our own eyes, that only ד' is the One who gives us our sustenance at all times. This became our reality. We did not have any food prepared from one day to the next, and every day we turned our eyes towards ד' and waited for the מן to come down from שמים². Through this, we became accustomed to living with אמונה and בטחון, and came close to ד' and it was possible to give us the תורה, as it says in (מדרש תנחומא בשלח) "חז"ל (לא ניתנה תורה אלא לאוכלי המן".

Another reason can be given why the מדה of בטחון enables us to receive the תורה. When a person has בטחון, his heart is vacant of desires and his mind is settled, and he trusts that ד' is taking care of him and placing before him all that he needs in the best way possible. חז"ל say in ב' כ"ח ב' "שמעתתא בעי צילותא", that in order to understand what one is learning, he must have a settled and calm mind. It is impossible for one who is lacking בטחון to have a settled mind, as it says in חז"ל "ריחיים על צוארו ויעסוק בתורה?", "With a millstone on his neck, how it is possible for him to learn תורה? We see from this that the מדה of בטחון is necessary in order to achieve תורה. This was the state of בני"י in מדבר at the time of מתן תורה. They were eating מן and they were surrounded by ענני הכבוד, which were ironing their clothes for them. They were completely relying on ד' and had בטחון only in ד'. They had no physical worries.

So too, it is necessary to have בטחון if one who wants to receive the new תורה that ד' is bestowing upon all of בני"י every day. When we recite ברכות התורה, we say "המלמד תורה לעמו ישראל", which means that ד' is teaching us תורה every day. In order to be worthy to receive the תורה, ד' has given us a situation similar to the time of מתן תורה. This is the מצוה of שמיטה, which we have once every seven years. We must abandon the land and forget about our fields and our vineyards, and trust only in ד', as דור המדבר did. Through this, we will be able to receive the תורה anew at least once every seven years. After we have demonstrated this בטחון for a full year, it will be strengthened in our hearts and we will continue to live this way even after the year is over. Since it is in our טבע that every new thing grows old and is forgotten from our hearts, ד' has given us this opportunity every seven years in order to reawaken in our hearts the state that we were in the מדבר and allow us to actualize our בטחון and it will remain in our hearts forever, בס"ד.

This explanation is similar to the אגרא דכלא mentioned above and it teaches us to be like to generation of the מדבר, who ate the מן and had complete בטחון in ד'. By doing so, we become worthy to receive the תורה anew. .

"If you say: What will we eat?" - "וכי תאמרו מה נאכל...וצויתי את ברכתי" (כ"ה כ'-כ"א)

² Even though they did not reach this level through their own efforts, rather, it was given to them by ד', and usually one who wants to reach this level and live with complete בטחון, much invest great effort and fight to overcome big challenges, still, eating the מן was a great challenge for בני"י, as it says (שמות ט"ז ד') - "למען ענותך לנסותך לדעת את אשר בלבבך",

The **נועם אלימלך** asks in the name of his brother, **ר' זושא** - Why does the **תורה** mention the question **"וכי תאמרו מה נאכל"** - "And if you say what shall we eat?" when the **תורה** could have simply said **"וצויתי את ברכתי"** - "I will command my blessing" - and then no questions would be raised. He answers that the **תורה** wants to teach us that if we do not ask this question and we put our trust in **ד'** then the **שפע** (abundance) which would come down in the sixth year would be enough for the seventh and eighth years and the **תורה** would not have to say **"וצויותי"** - "I will command my blessing". Our question of "What will we eat?" shows a lack of **בטחון** in **ד'**, as if He will not take care of us when, in truth, He is always taking care of us. The result is that the **שפע** stops and we now require a new blessing from **ד'** in order that there should be enough grain for the seventh and eighth years.

We can add to his holy words a well known concept, which is that the **שמיטה** of **מצוה** is in order to allow us to achieve and actualize the **מדה** of **בטחון**. Therefore, when a person asks "What shall I eat?", it is an insult to **ד'**, so to speak, because He commanded us not to plant and therefore, obviously He will support us and we will not be damaged by keeping the **מצוות** that **ד'** commanded us to keep. It is a great lack of **אמונה** in **ד'** to suspect that He will not take care of us during this time. This is truly a mistake and a terrible **ד' חילול**. Therefore, a person who asks this question would be deserving of the punishment of having the **שפע** held back from him yet, even so, **ד'** commands a **ברכה**, since after all, he is fulfilling the **מצוה** of **שמיטה**, even though he is lacking the **פנימיות** of the **מצוה**. The reason he is not being punished is because **ד'** does not hold back reward from any creature. However, we must be aware that this is far from the ideal observance of the **מצוה** of **שמיטה**.

We can also learn from the holy words of the **נועם אלימלך** an important lesson, that only **בטחון** draws down upon a person **שפע** and **ברכה**. The opposite is true as well- a lack of **בטחון** ruins and cancels the **שפע** that a person was supposed to receive³. A person must be very careful during a time when he has an offer from a client to buy his merchandise and he sees an opportunity to

³ It is told about the **חפץ חיים** that his family members wanted to buy fire insurance for his house and the **חפץ חיים** did not want it. Even after much attempt at convincing him, he refused. In the end, they bought the insurance policy without him knowing and after a while, there was a big fire in the city and all of the houses burned down, including the house of the **חפץ חיים**. His children came to him and said that he should not worry because they had bought the insurance policy. They said "After all, we were right. It was a miracle that we bought the insurance policy because if we had not, we would have had nothing left". The **חפץ חיים** immediately responded "You do not understand. The opposite is true. Had you not bought the insurance, my house would not have burned down since there was no decree in **שמים** for me to have such a loss. Only because you bought the insurance, now I have to move to a new house and buy everything all over again. This is very hard for me. If only you would have had the **מדה** of **בטחון** you would have spared me all of this trouble". We see from this story that a lack in the **מדה** of **בטחון** is what causes damage, ח"ו.

Addition from the editor- I asked the **rov**, **שליט"א**, why did the **חפץ חיים** have to go through this trouble. After all, it was his household that had the lack of **בטחון**, not him, and they did it behind his back. The **rov** answered that in truth, the **חפץ חיים** did not suffer from this at all. He continued learning as he always did and they had to run around and do all the work. We learn from this that they only caused themselves damage. The **rov** continued by adding a **פסוק** from **דברים** - "שחת לו לא בניו מומם..." - "Corruption is not His- the blemish is His children's".

make a lot of money. He may allow himself to worry about how he and his merchandise should find favor in the eyes of the buyer and his mind may become preoccupied with this. Sometimes, he cannot focus during his davening and his learning because he is so caught up with this. The reason for this is because he is lacking in the מדה of בטחון. If he would believe that what he is meant to receive has already been decreed upon and he will not receive a penny more, then what place is there for this worry? The השתדלות that a person is required to do is only to fulfill the גזרה and the תיקון of "בזיעת אפך תאכל לחם" – "By the sweat of your brow you shall eat bread" (which was given after the חטא of אדם הראשון). When a person is filled with worry, he shows that he believes and thinks that his success is dependent on his השתדלות. Through this, he can ruin and cancel the שפע that he was destined to receive, ח"ו. Therefore, it is important to remove this from his mind and not to worry about it. He should cast his burden on ד' and have בטחון that ד' will give him what is good for him. What is not decreed for him, he will not receive because he has no need for it and it is not good for him. With this, a person will always be calm and have שמחה and לב טוב to serve ד' with ישוב הדעת.

We can learn from this a מוסר השכל with regards to שידוכים. A person should not worry at all. Many people are caught up and worried about themselves or that their children should have good שידוכים. Therefore, they over worry about every small detail from the time their children are young. They worry if every small thing is suitable in the eyes of the world. Due to this, they overlook important matters of עולם הבא, such as not sending them to a ישיבה that is known to be successful in תורה and יראת שמים, because they are worried that they will not find favor in the eyes of the world. This itself could be the reason that they do not receive a good שידוך. Because of these calculations, they are only causing damage to their children who are not receiving a higher level of חינוך and through this, losing out on עולם הבא. Even worse than this is that they are raising their children with the השקפה that every decision must be made according to what the world will say. The children grow up thinking that this is the proper way to behave and they do not realize that in truth, the only thing that should be taken into account is what the אמת and what is the השקפה of the תורה is on this matter, even if it will not find favor in the eyes of the world. When one does not do this, it is as though he is serving ע"ז – the ע"ז of pleasing the public, himself, and his honor, instead of serving ד'. This is a great insult to ד', and the basic אמונה that He decides everything and is leading the world⁴.

Sometimes, a person can be tested in a way which it seems as though the reason he lost out was because he did not take into account what people will say. However, in truth, according to the אמת of השקפה and אמונה, it is only נסיון which is being placed before him to see whether or not his אמונה is strong and whether or not he will be affected by the way things seem externally.

⁴ Even though חז"ל teach us in (ג' י') פרקי אבות that if a person is pleasing in the eyes of others, he is pleasing in the eyes of ד', this is only referring to those whose השקפה and behavior are in accordance with the ways of the תורה and מסורה.

It is written in **ספר החינוך (מצוה רמ"ז)** that one of the fundamental foundations of **אמונה** is to believe that no person can cause damage to another person if that damage was not decreed in **שמים**. If it was decreed upon, then it will come to him anyways. If not through this person or reason, then it would come about in another way. **ד'** has many messengers. According to what has been explained, a person can only ruin things for himself through a lack in **בטחון**. A person who has complete **בטחון** in **ד'** will not be harmed through walking on the path of **אמת** and **צדק**. This specifically applies to the topic of **שידוכים**, since it is brought in **גמרא סוטה** that 40 days before a fetus is created, it is called out who will be its **זיווג**. Also, it says in the **פסוק -אשה -מד' איש** matches are made from **ד'**.⁵

" וצויתי את ברכתי "

Understanding what has been said above, that when we ask the question "**מה נאכל**", we are causing the **שפע** to be held back, we can point out a difficulty in the second half of the **פסוק**. Instead of saying "**וצויתי את הברכה**" - "I will command the **ברכה**", the **פסוק** says "**וצויתי את ברכתי**" - "I will command my **ברכה**". It is possible to understand this in two ways. The first way is according to what **רש"י** says in the previous **פסוק**, that the words "**ואכלתם לשובע**" mean that we will eat a small amount, there will be a **ברכה** in it, and we will feel full. In the same way, when we harvest the produce of the sixth year, even though it will not be a large amount, it will have a **ברכה** and we will feel full, even with the small amount that we eat. Therefore, the produce will last for three years. In this way we will also spare ourselves the hard work of harvesting the extra produce. This would not be the case if the **ברכה** would bring a big **שפע** of produce because we would have to work double on the sixth year. By lacking **בטחון** and asking "**מה נאכל**", we suffer greatly. If we would have **בטחון** and not ask this question, the produce would be enough for three years without all the extra work. There would be "**ברכה** in our stomach", meaning that we would eat a small amount and be satisfied. When we ask "**מה נאכל**", we show that we are lacking **בטחון** in **ד'**, and therefore receive the **ברכה** of having a big **שפע** of produce, and along with it all the hard work of harvesting for the following two years.

The second possible explanation is as follows: The **מצוה** of **שמיטה** is an opportunity to achieve **רוחניות**. A person develops his **מדה** of **בטחון**, which gives him a strong connection to **ד'**, and he can receive the **תורה** in a way that he has never received it before. This is the unique **ברכה** that **ד'** has prepared to give us during **שמיטה**. Those who ask "**מה נאכל**" are showing that they have not yet begun working on the **מדה** of **בטחון** and have not done anything to prepare themselves to receive this **מדה** during **שמיטה**. Therefore, they are losing out on the **רוחניות** as well as the inner purpose of this **מצוה**. Also, through this they are taking the **ברכה** that **ד'** prepared for them and turning it in to a **שפע גשמי** instead of a **שפע רוחני**, which is like changing light for darkness.

⁵ It is brought in the name of the **גרי"ז** of **בריסק** that even though a person is required to make a **השתדלות בדרך** **השתדלות** **בדרך**, with regards to **שידוכים** one needs to make less **השתדלות** than with other things.

With what has been said, we can explain that the word "ברכת" means my ברכה that I have prepared for you. I will now command it to give something different than what I had originally intended. It is a great שפלות that the ברכה falls from its original אור רוחני into the חושך גשמי of this world. The מלאך that was in charge of the ברכה, and was waiting to fulfill his שליחות in order to give נחת רוח to his Creator, becomes very disappointed that he is forced into a new שליחות, as the word "צויתי" is hinting at (the לשון of צויתי is fierce).

We can learn a great מוסר השכל from this, that whenever a person is occupied with a מצוה he must be careful not worry about the גשמיות that he will lose out on through keeping the מצוה because through this, he can cause himself to lose out on the שפע רוחני that he is meant to receive through the מצוה. Rather, he must shift his mind off all גשמיות during the time that he is occupied with the מצוה. This is also true regarding תפילה. When a person is davening, he must not allow thoughts of his physical matters to enter his mind. He must turn off his phone during davening and learning, because if he receives a call in the middle and he even just looks to see who is calling him, this will already place distracting thoughts in his mind and can cause him to lose out on the שפע that he was going to receive through his learning and his davening.

One who has בטחון in ד' will be surrounded with חסד and will bring down upon himself a great שפע רוחני more than what was meant for him and more that he could have imagined.

" שתינו עמלים בתורה " (רש"י כ"ו ג')

רש"י says that the words "אם בחקתי תלכו" mean that we should be עמלים בתורה (toil in תורה). The reward that the תורה promises is that we will receive everything we need in its proper time. The question is asked- Why is this reward given specifically for עמלות בתורה as opposed to general תורה study? Further on in the פרשה the תורה speaks about all of the punishments we will receive for not keeping the תורה. As we know, everything that ד' does is מדה כנגד מדה. We also know that suffering comes for two main purposes, which are to awaken us to do תשובה and to cleanse us of our עבירות, as it says in חז"ל and in the רמב"ם that there are four different processes that provide a כפרה. There are certain עבירות that even after doing תשובה and fasting on יו"כ, they still require כפרה through suffering.

It says in מסכת זבחים that when there is no בית המקדש, a person who is חייב to bring a קרבן as a כפרה, can instead achieve his כפרה through learning the הלכות of the קרבן that he would have been required to bring. It is brought in ספרי מוסר that the same is true with all other עבירות, after a person does תשובה for them, he can still fix what he needs to fix through studying the פרשה in the תורה which speaks about the עבירה that he has committed. Also, if a person missed out on fulfilling a מצוה, he can "make up for it" by studying the הלכות of that מצוה.

It also says in the ספרים הקדושים that if it is decreed on a person that he must suffer יסורים to fix his עבירות, he can spare himself these יסורים through intense strenuous עמלות בתורה. This עמלות will be instead of the יסורים he was supposed to receive and will cleanse him of his עבירות in the

same way that יסורים cleanse (one of the תיקונים instead of כרת is to deprive oneself of sleep and study all night).

With רש"י's explanation on this פסוק, it becomes clear that "אם בחקתי תלכו" is an introduction to the פרשה of תוכחה. The פסוק means to say if you will be עמל בתורה, you will not have any צער in the world. Even a person who has פרנסה can experience a lot of אגמת נפש when his salary is held back and he has to chase after people and his mind is always occupied with it. Because of this, he has no מנוחה הנפש. Such a situation is surely a תיקון for one's עבירות. This is why the פסוק tells us here that if a person would have עמלות בתורה with all of his strength on the level of "ממית עצמו", he can spare himself all of the suffering mentioned in the פרשה and through this, his פרנסה will come easily at the right time without having to chase after it. The שפע will appear on its own. As it says in the פסוק "והשיג לכם דיש וגו'" - The שפע will catch up to you as though it is chasing after you and you will not need to chase after it.

When a person brings this type of יסורים upon himself through עמלות בתורה, it is certainly much less painful than what would have come through other יסורים for a few reasons. The first reason is that this צער is worth much more because it is צער for the sake of a מצוה. The second reason is that since the person is bringing it upon himself out of love for the תורה, it brings his תיקון much quicker with less יסורים, as is brought in ספרי מוטר that when a person is מקבל his באהבה, he achieves his תיקון with much less יסורים. Even more so, if he is happy with the יסורים, it makes things much easier. There is an advantage in עמלות בתורה which is different than all other יסורים, which is that all other יסורים bring one to עצבות and take away one's שמחה. This is not the case with תורה, which naturally brings a person to שמחה, as it says in the פסוק "פקודי ד' ישרים משמחי לב". Naturally, when a person has הנאה and שמחה from something, it takes the strain away. Therefore, even if a person experiences the full measure of יסורים that he deserves, it will be easier for him because they will not be felt as strongly as other יסורים. The שמחה that a person experiences is like a shot of anesthesia that takes away the pain.

Therefore, a person must take to heart during his learning תורה that if he is not being successful and he sees that he must strain himself very intensely until he understands what he is learning, he should not be pained from this at all. Rather, he should understand that it is all for his own good⁶ because through this he is being given the opportunity to free himself from a lot of יסורים that

⁶ It says in the זוהר הקדוש that a person who wakes up at חצות to study תורה, the תורה informs him of his עבירות and what he must correct, meaning that while learning תורה, the תורה puts in his mind the severity of his עבירות. However, this is not done in a way of judgment and יסורים. Rather, like a mother explaining to her child gently where he has gone wrong. This causes him not to forget his עבירות and brings him to do תשובה.

We can possibly explain that the reason why studying תורה at חצות gives a person this זכות to awaken him to do תשובה in such a way is because of the צער that he goes through depriving himself of sleep (depriving oneself of sleep can be a כפרה for the punishment of כרת). ל"א - חצות תורה at חצות say regarding the greatness of learning תורה. "לא - חצות תורה" - אברי לילה אלא לגירסא - The night was only created for the study of תורה. We see from this that night time is one of the best times to study תורה. Also the רמב"ם says that a person achieves most of his חכמה at night and therefore, he should not waste even one night. It is true that when one has עמלות בתורה during the day it is also a big זכות, but getting up to study תורה at night is even greater.

were intended to come upon him. He is freeing himself from them very easily through עמלות with שמחה and a good heart. Also, he should be happy that this is the type of suffering that is coming upon him, since it also uplifts and refreshes a person, as opposed to other יסורים which are painful and could weigh down on a person. A person can also be בשמחה that his יסורים were given to him in such a way that he merits to be among those who sit in the בית מדרש and not in a hospital, ח"ו, with a physical or mental disability or in jail. While a person is עמל בתורה, he should focus on the fact that it is a כפרה for his עבירות.

“Also I will behave towards you” - “והלכתי אף אני עמכם...” (כ"ו כ"ד)

מדה כנגד מדה

In this פסוק the תורה says that if we act casually with ד', ד' will also act casually with us. Both the מדה כנגד מדה and the אור החיים הקדוש explain that when ד' punishes a person, it is done מדה כנגד מדה. This is for his benefit because through the punishment, the person can realize and understand what his עבירה was. He can then do תשובה to fix it and the punishment and the suffering will end.

However, this applies only the first time that the יסורים come upon a person, only then are they given מדה כנגד מדה. However, if a person did not take it to heart and awaken himself to do תשובה (and instead he says that things like this just happen and he blames it on nature or on the person who caused it) or examine and understand that it has come to him specifically for his sins, it is as though he is ignoring that what happened is a חסד from ד' to awaken him and help him do תשובה. Then, when the יסורים come upon him a second time, they come in a way which is not clearly מדה כנגד מדה and he is not able to see and understand for which עבירה he must do תשובה. According to this explanation of the מדה כנגד מדה and the אור החיים הקדוש, the פסוקים read as follows- If a person says about his יסורים which came upon him, that they are random, then ד' says back “I too will bring upon you יסורים that are not similar to your bad deeds”.

This is seemingly a great חידוש, because it means that the חז"ל that כלל have taught us that the punishment one receives in מדה כנגד מדה is only true the first time. If so, חז"ל should have told us that. Who would come to this on their own? The answer could be as follows: The חז"ל that כלל of מדה כנגד מדה is really always true. However, what the מפרשים are telling us is that there is a small difference between the first time and the second time that one receives a punishment for a specific עבירה. The second time, even though the יסורים are מדה כנגד מדה, they are not given in a clear way that one could realize on his own the מדה כנגד מדה. Because of this, it is difficult to understand though the יסורים what one has to do תשובה for. However, if one would sit and do חשבון הנפש and go through all of his deeds, the reason for his יסורים will certainly become clear to him. However, it will not be as easy as it would have been had he done תשובה the first time.

It is necessary to know that this too is מדה כנגד מדה since the first time that a person was נכשל (stumbled) and began following the advice of his יצר הרע, ד' still loves this person very much and He still speaks to him as a mother who punishes her child in a very clear way. Out of her great

love for him, she speaks to him with the warmth of her heart, with loving words and specifically tells him, directs him, and teaches him how to fix his ways. However, if he does not take her words to heart and he turns away with stubbornness and coldness as though she is a stranger who is speaking to him, then in order that he should understand and feel the wrong that he has done, not only the first mistake, but also his cold behavior towards her, she too begins to behave to him in a cold way in order that he should feel how much it hurts when people behave coldly, and through this he will understand how offensive he was by not taking to heart her original loving words.

Still, she does not stop loving him or ignore him in the way that he completely ignored her. If she would behave towards him in the same manner that he behaved, she would not speak to him at all, she would allow him to completely disconnect from her. However, because a mother has חסד and רחמנות on her child, she does not behave towards him with exacting measure. Rather, she punishes him, but not as loving or as soft spoken as the first time, in order that he should know what he has done. Through this, he will learn his lesson and wake up. She continues to behave in this way as long as he remains cold towards her. This is how it goes on, as long as there is distance from his side, she will continue to distance herself, מדה כנגד מדה, similar to the פסוקים in the תוכחה, "ואם בזאת לא תשמעו והלכתם עמי בקרי", if you do not listen, and behave as though everything is coincidence, then "ויסרתי אתכם", I will bring יסורים upon you. The תורה continues describing every time he punishes us and we still do not respond. The מדה כנגד מדה element of the punishment becomes more and more concealed.

It is necessary to understand that 'ד's behavior in this way towards us is for our benefit and it is due to 'ד's great חסד because He wills that the תשובה do רשעים. Therefore, He does not completely turn away from us, he continues to awaken us, similar to the way that we behave towards him, מדה כנגד מדה. A person who chooses to pay attention will understand the hints that 'ד is giving him and will return to 'ד.

Once a person has become very distant from 'ד, even when he wakes up to do תשובה, it is very difficult for him to know what he must correct and what was his original עבירה which brought him to the rest of his עבירות. If he would know and he would correct the root of it, he would manage to correct everything. However, because he has turned away from 'ד so many times, even though he was receiving hints מן השמים מדה, מדה כנגד מדה he does not deserve to return so easily.

If this person truly wants to do תשובה, he must first do תשובה for his coldness towards 'ד, as it says in the פסוק - "והתודו את אונם...ואף אשר הלכו עמי בקרי" -פסוק - "They will do תשובה for behaving towards me casually". Therefore, he must exert much effort and do תשובה for anything and everything he can possibly think of. Through this effort he will have a תיקון for turning away from the hints that 'ד was previously sending him. שער רבינו יונה says in תשובה that the עבירה of postponing תשובה, specifically when a person has the ability to do תשובה and does not, is more severe, and the punishment is more severe, than for the עבירה itself.



With this we can understand why in our generation, during these times, there are so many disasters and strange things happening. There are all kinds of punishments and physical suffering of the body and of the נפש. The reason for this is because we are behaving with the קשי מדה of קשי עורף, very stubbornly, and not awakening ourselves despite all of the צרות which are happening personally and in the whole world. We are not taking to heart that we must look into our actions and do תשובה and change our ways for the good. Because of our great חטאים and our stubbornness, we are confident that the כונה is not to awaken us and we feel that we have not sinned. Each person's ways are correct in his eyes and he thinks that the hints are intended for others, as if there is no קטרוג (prosecution) or complaint against him, since after all, he is a חרדי Jew and his way is straight, as if he is one of the צדיקים. In truth, every person must always be careful and suspect that maybe he is mistaken in his השקפה and he may not realize he is mistaken, and really he is full of עבירות that he is not aware of. Only because of his גאווה (personal interests), and heart's desires he does not see that he is full of עבירות, ח"ו, but really מן השמים they want him to change his ways for the good. This is the way of true צדיקים to always suspect themselves of עבירות that they have never done.

We have seen from above that we must take to heart and pay attention to all of the צרות, natural disasters, and troubles which are happening today all over the world because they are all hints to awaken us to do תשובה for our behavior, and this is what is causing all of these צרות. May it be ש' will that a great התעוררות come upon us from above and may we take to heart and begin to understand what lays before us. May we return to ד' before it is too late, lest we be left shameful and embarrassed. Rather, we should merit doing תשובה שלמה and seeing the שלמה with great גאולה. במהרה בימינו אמן, חסדים and רחמים.

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